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The Mystical Dimension of History in
Joachim of Fiore, Bonaventure, and Peter Olivi

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“Mysticism” is a muddle; this much we know. Bernard McGinn’s *Presence of God*, a *magnum opus et arduum* if there ever was one, has fruitfully gathered nearly 1500 years of material around this modern category of “mysticism,” fully aware of the risk of anachronism, and yet convinced that there is something worth discussing – and something substantial enough to fill five thick volumes! But the scholarly critiques of Denys Turner and others have questioned whether McGinn is in fact undoing his own best efforts to respect the tradition by distinguishing the ‘mystical’ as an identifiable topic of theology. For Turner, “theology in so far as it is theology is ‘mystical’ and in so far as it is mystical it is theology.”¹ And yet how else does one describe the intentional reflection on the ‘presence of God’ that McGinn has chronicled? Surely there is a ‘mystical’ dimension to Christology, but Bonaventure’s

1. Denys Turner, *The Darkness of God: Negativity in Christian Mysticism* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995), 265. Perhaps McGinn might respond, in a scholastic fashion, that he is distinguishing in order to unite.

Christology in the ‘Disputed Questions on the Knowledge of Christ’ is quite different in its shape and intention from the *Itinerarium mentis in Deum*. If theology and the ‘mystical’ are utterly synonymous, without remainder, how do we describe the genre of the *Itinerarium*?

I begin with this conundrum, which may seem tangential in light of my title, in the hopes of sketching the parameters of what I am and *am not* trying to do. The essay is intended to identify the mystical element in the apocalyptic theology of history and eschatology of three medieval thinkers, whose distinctive contribution McGinn himself acknowledges. In his brief discussion of Joachim of Fiore in the second volume, McGinn suggests that, in Joachim’s thought, we find “a new form of corporate social mysticism of an apocalyptic character, . . . one which will have a further history, if only a minor one, in the centuries to come.”² While I might agree (with an admittedly bad pun) that Joachim’s legacy is indeed a “Minor” one (that is, one that is carried on primarily among the Franciscans, the ‘Friars Minor’), it is not a ‘new form of mysticism’ that they forge. Rather, Joachim, Bonaventure, and Olivi recognize and develop intentionally the *mystical element* in their apocalyptic theologies of history. That is, Joachim’s innovative approach to the theology of history and its development and expansion in the thought of St. Bonaventure and Peter Olivi share an insight into how history is itself mystagogical.

I. Introduction: The “Mystical Element” in Joachim?

Joachim of Fiore has attracted a lot of scholarly attention over the years, but seldom is he thought of as a mystical thinker.³ In fact, some recent thinkers have distinguished Joachim’s thought by its *non*-mystical character. Recently, Ilia Delio, OSF has discussed the relationship between Bonaventure and Joachim under the thesis is that “mystical union ultimately distinguishes Bonaventure’s eschatology from Joachim’s.”⁴ That is, she argues that Joachim’s eschatology is “prophetic,” but not “mystical.” Bonaventure’s debt to Joachim is deep, she concedes, but his particular contribution is to introduce this ‘mystical’ dimension into Joachite eschatology. In this

2. Bernard McGinn, *The Growth of Mysticism. The Presence of God, vol. 2* (New York: Crossroad, 1994), 341. McGinn there cites an earlier, unpublished version of this essay (568n.64) as influential on his treatment of Joachim.

3. See, among others, Marjorie Reeves, *The Influence of Prophecy in the later Middle Ages* (reprint, Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1993); Bernard McGinn, *The Calabrian Abbot: Joachim of Fiore in the History of Western Thought* (New York: Macmillan, 1985). Note that even McGinn, the scholar of mysticism, makes no comment on Joachim as a mystical thinker, and ‘mystic,’ ‘mysticism,’ or any variation makes no appearance in the index.

4. “From Prophecy to Mysticism: Bonaventure’s Eschatology in Light of Joachim of Fiore,” *Traditio* 52 (1997) 154. I do not dispute her particular claims about the different weight Christology bears in each thinker, nor do I disagree that the mystical dimension of Bonaventure’s eschatology emerges most clearly in light of the *Itinerarium mentis ad Deum*, as the reader will see. However, I argue that, by re-framing the heuristic device of ‘the mystical,’ we can better understand the similarities and differences between the abbot and the doctor. Peter Olivi’s place in the paper is to show yet another construal of the mystical element of history, both to strengthen the common core notion and to put the differences in sharper relief.

move, Delio captures the prevailing scholarly sense of Joachim as an apocalyptic and prophetic thinker, but not as a mystic.

One of the few scholars to consider Joachim as a mystical thinker is himself so idiosyncratic that his influence on scholarly discussion has been slight. In 1929, the journal *Ricerche Religiose* published a controversial article entitled "Il misticismo di Gioacchino da Fiore," by Ernesto Buonaiuti. According to Buonaiuti, mysticism is expressed in two profoundly different visions: a solitary mysticism and ". . . a corporate-social mysticism (*un misticismo associato*), in which the divine is found all at once in the fraternal participation in the same charismatic revelation and hence all in the same revealed reality. Joachim of Fiore, together with the sources of prophetic literature and the New Testament, is of this second type."⁵ In Buonaiuti's vision, Joachim appears as the poetic prophet of a coming time, the Age of the Holy Spirit, when God will communicate with God's people directly, as a revealed reality shared by a community. This divine immanence, this unmediated revelation, constitutes for Buonaiuti a corporate-social mysticism, a mystical union that is shared in community, such that it is simultaneously union with God and with one another.⁶ In so arguing, Buonaiuti not only challenged scholars' understanding of the strange and elusive Abbot of Fiore, but also stretched the very concept of "mysticism" itself.

What Buonaiuti finds in Joachim's thought is a specifically social or communal dimension to the mystical life. For Buonaiuti, this social dimension, which he called the *vita associata*, lay at the very heart of Christianity, what William Murphy has called "the charismatic bonds that form a trans-empirical agapaic community."⁷ Any solitary model of mysticism characterized by the turn to the religious subject outside the context of a community is a corruption of the religious life.⁸ For Buonaiuti, the *vita associata* is not unique to Christianity. He argues that it is a Mediterranean religious impulse shared by Greeks, Iranians, Romans, and Jews alike, coming to full intellectual fruition in Christianity.

5. ". . . *un misticismo associato che trova unicamente il divino nella partecipazione fraterna alle medesime rivelazioni carismatiche e quindi alle medesime realtà rivelati; il misticismo di Gioacchino da Fiore, come quello della letteratura profetica e di quella neotestamentario, appariente al secondo tipo.*" Ernesto Buonaiuti, "Il misticismo di Gioacchino da Fiore," reprinted in *Saggi di storia del Cristianesimo*, A. Donini & M. Nicoli, eds. (Vicenza, 1957), 381.

6. For the sake of convenience, I will refer to this concept with the short-hand 'social mysticism.' However, I do not wish the reader to lose the "corporate" sense of the term – that we refer to a mystical knowledge that is not only shared, (social), but is shared in such a way that it draws those who share in it into an organic solidarity in the Body of Christ.

7. William Murphy, *Vita Associata and Religious Experience in the Writings of Ernesto Buonaiuti* (Rome: Pontificia Universitas Gregoriana, 1974), 19.

8. Buonaiuti's vision stands in stark contrast to that of his contemporary, William James, whose famous definition of religion is "the feelings, acts, and experiences of individual men in their solitude, so far as they apprehend themselves to stand in relation to whatever they may consider the divine." In *Varieties of Religious Experience* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1985), p. 31.

Admittedly, Buonaiuti's idealism is heavily biased. In the a postmodern context, we have become perhaps less sanguine about such a claim to have identified the ideal religious core of Mediterranean culture. But Buonaiuti's theory nonetheless may offer a useful, if oft forgotten, lens for the study of Joachim. For, on this account, if Joachim's thought is mystical, it is only in this social, ecclesial sense. In other words, Joachim's mystical dimension is found particularly in his vision of the *ecclesia contemplativa*. But, as we shall see, such a vision is so thoroughly integrated into his unique apocalyptic theology of history that it does not constitute a 'new form of mysticism.' Rather, it sheds the insights of mystical theology as illumined by Origen, Gregory the Great, and Bernard of Clairvaux on the theological interpretation of history. The contribution of Bonaventure then is to apply the Dionysian schematics of mystical theology to Joachim's insight; that of Olivi is to develop a more robust Franciscan understanding of contemplation in the *ecclesia contemplativa*.

To discern each thinker's contribution, we must ask two interrelated questions. First, how is the mystical element reflected in the *apocalyptic course of history* as outlined by the three? Second, how is the mystical dimension reflected *eschatologically* in what all three called the 'contemplative church'? Answering this latter question will draw upon classical 'mystical theology' for points of contact, but it will also press us to examine the specifically social dimension of mystical thought recognized by Buonaiuti. These questions offer a way of understanding the contributions of our three thinkers in a critical, comparative light. The analysis of their thought will then yield an opportunity to reflect more deeply and concretely upon the connection between 'mysticism' and the theology of history, and, at least by analogy, to other areas of theology as well.

***II. History--The Path toward Contemplation*⁹**

Joachim is of course best known for his innovative apocalyptic theology of history, and it is well known that Bonaventure and Peter Olivi are deeply influenced by his work. The three share a linear vision of history marked by the Church's progress into deeper and deeper "spiritual understanding" of God. In all three, the apocalyptic process of spiritual transformation seems to take on the character of a mystical path for the Church as a whole. However, this is not to say that it is a discipline, a chosen *ascesis* that we often find in mystical texts. Like all apocalyptic schema, it is a divinely determined course of events: the Church necessarily unfolds in history toward the contemplative end. Despite this determinism, individual freedom is preserved, for individuals choose whether to remain in the Church or to abandon it in the face of tribulation. The contemplative

9. Much of this section of the essay rehearses what can be found in the best treatments of Joachim, Bonaventure, and Olivi, but its contribution is in plotting the apocalyptic course of each thinker in terms of a path of mystical ascent and in placing these figures in comparative relief. For the individual works I have found most useful are McGinn, *The Calabrian Abbot* (New York: Macmillan, 1984); Ratzinger, *The Theology of History of St. Bonaventure* (New York: Franciscan Herald Press, 1970); and David Burr, *The Persecution of Peter Olivi* (Philadelphia: American Philosophical Society, 1976). See also McGinn, "The Significance of Bonaventure's Theology of History." *Journal of Religion* 58 (1978), 64-81; Burr, "Olivi, Apocalyptic Expectation, and Visionary Experience." *Traditio* 41 (1985), 273-285.

"fulfillment" of the path consists in a mystical union of the entire Church with God *in history*, before Judgment and the heavenly life of the blessed.

A. Joachim of Fiore

The theology of history which Joachim of Fiore created and Bonaventure and Peter Olivi developed was a progressive, apocalyptic eschatology of the Church. As Bernard McGinn has noted, apocalyptic eschatology conceives of history as a "divinely predetermined, universal teleological process."¹⁰ It is not progressive in the modern sense of the term; human actions cannot contribute to its development. Instead, history is the theater of God's plan, gradually unfolding in human events. Though radically determined, apocalyptic eschatology offers comfort in the knowledge that God's will triumphs in the end, with Judgment, condemnation of the damned, and eternal life of the blessed. Human freedom lies in the choice of a side.

Joachim of Fiore's apocalypticism never departs from these essential characteristics; yet, at the same time, it represents perhaps the most innovative adaptation of apocalyptic thought in the medieval Christian tradition. Joachim schematizes history in two fundamental ways. First, he accepts the traditional division of time into two dispensations, that of the Old Testament and that of the New. The New Testament supersedes the Old, such that Joachim can clearly say, "*datus est finis veteri testamento*." ("There is the end of the Old Testament.")¹¹ But Joachim adapts another traditional exegetical schema to this division into dispensations. He makes use of the traditional "world-week" formula of world history by doubling it, creating what Marjorie Reeves calls the "double-sevens" pattern. The history of each dispensation is divided into seven "times," (*tempora*) such that each *tempus* in the Old Dispensation is correlated with one in the New.

Secondly, he divides history into three *status*, corresponding to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit:

The time of law and grace is distinguished in three *status*: under law, under grace, and under greater grace; since he has given us, as Scripture says, 'grace upon grace.' [Jn 1.16] Now the first status is ascribed to the Father, the second to the Son, and the third to the Holy Spirit.¹²

Joachim does not argue that each stage of history is solely the province of one person of the Trinity; his trinitarian theology is too sophisticated for that. "For, just as there are three persons and one God, so frequently in those things that are common to all three distinct significations are found that show

10. Bernard McGinn, "John's Apocalypse and the Apocalyptic Mentality," *The Apocalypse in the Middle Ages* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1992), Richard K. Emmerson and Bernard McGinn, eds., 7.

11. Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1972), 10. See also *Expos.* ff. 9^v - 10^r.

12. "In tribus denique statibus distinguitur tempus legis et gratiae: sub lege, sub gratia, sub amplior gratia; quia gratiam, inquit, pro gratia dedit nobis. Et primus quidem ascribitur Patri, secundus Filio, tertius Spiritui sancto . . ." *Ench.* ll. 462-465.

the respective likeness of the persons."¹³ The *status* are named for the particular revelation of the glory of one person.

St. Augustine, too, had divided history by law and grace, but, in so doing, he placed himself in the last age, under grace, from Christ to Judgment. Joachim, on the other hand, finds himself living in the second status, under the grace of the Gospel, anticipating a future state:

The second status is under the Gospel. It remains to the present, with a certain liberty with respect to the past, but not in liberty with respect to the future. . . . The third status, then, will be ushered at the end of the world, no longer under the veil of the letter, but in the full freedom of the spirit.¹⁴

The anticipation of a future state of grace *within history* sets Joachim apart from Augustine and other Christian theologians of history. History thus moves progressively through each *status*, growing in greater and greater freedom. For Joachim, the fullness of that freedom is realized historically.

Marjorie Reeves argues that the three-*status* division in Joachim is distinct from the division into dispensations inasmuch as it portrays spiritual growth rather than particular periodization. Thus, the *status* can and do overlap: the third *status* begins within the second, in the person of Benedict. The analogy of spiritual growth becomes evident in a sort of litany in the *Liber concordie*:

The first status was in knowledge, the second in the authority of wisdom, the third in perfection of understanding. The first in the chains of a slave, the second in the service of a son, the third in freedom. The first in exasperation, the second in action, the third in contemplation. The first in fear, the second in faith, the third in love. . . . The first the age of children, the second the age of youth, the third that of the old. . . . The first in winter, the second in spring, the third in summer. The first the plant's seedling, the second roses, the third lilies. The first producing grass, the second stalks, the third wheat.¹⁵

He continues on, but the reader need not. Through the evocation of these traditional images of growth and progress in this repetitive litany, Joachim creates even in the language a sense of movement from the first to the third.

The measure of this spiritual growth in the three *status* is the level of Scriptural understanding. For Joachim, the Bible was the only source of knowledge. In it he found cosmology, ethics, and the "fullness of history"¹⁶ narrated and explained. Scripture's many truths are not self-evident or "plain," as some Reformation thinkers would later claim. Rather, the biblical texts contain an infinite,

13. *Lib. Conc.* II, Chapter 9, in Bernard McGinn, *Apocalyptic Spirituality* (New York: Paulist, 1979), 130.

14. *Expos.* 5^r. "*Secundus status fuit sub evangelio et manet undique nunc in libertate quidem respectu praeteriti, sed non in libertate respectu futuri. . . . Tertius ergo status erit circa finem saeculi, iam non sub velamine literae, sed in plena spiritus libertate.*"

15. *Lib. Conc.* 112^r

16. *Expos.* f. 64^{vb}. "*Qui dum verbum exiguum tangit, historiae plenitudinem comprehendit.*"

inexhaustible number of elusive mysteries to be uncovered by the exegete. "Manifold and hidden is the mystery of the Scriptures, changing from one form to another like soft wax."¹⁷ The exegete can only capture and unravel this mystery with the aid of *intellectus spiritualis*, "spiritual understanding." Without it, humans are enslaved to the letter. In the first *status*, humans are limited to the literal sense of the Scriptures, the law. His talk of "freedom" in the passages quoted above is, in fact, a developing freedom from the letter, the freedom of spiritual understanding.

Joachim's salvation history is the history of exegesis. Salvation began with Christ's Resurrection, but, more specifically, with the hermeneutical transformation it brought to pass, when "the tomb of the letter was opened, and the spiritual understanding appeared."¹⁸ Joachim is often criticized for his christology (or lack thereof), but one must note that Christ lies at the heart of Joachim's economy of salvation as the very origin of spiritual understanding in history. In the second *status*, spiritual understanding remains possible, but rare. More characteristic of this *status* is the *teaching* of the Gospel. In the third, spiritual understanding will reach its fullness. The nature of *intellectus spiritualis* will be discussed in greater depth when we examine its fulfillment in the third age. Our purpose here is simply to show its movement and development in history. The history of salvation, of the progress toward divine contemplation and spiritual perfection, consists in the movement from *letter* to *teaching* to *spiritual understanding* -- a pattern that suggests a mystical path from exterior to interior.¹⁹

Another of the many ways in which Joachim describes this progressive movement is in the symbolic shift from the number five to the number seven. Five and seven equal twelve, a number which represents completion. The number seven itself represents perfection. Joachim of Fiore sees in history the symbolic movement of fives into sevens. The five senses will yield to the seven gifts of the Holy Spirit. Five tribes of Israel received their inheritance first; seven tribes received it later. Similarly, five churches were founded under Peter, representing the active life; the Apocalypse tells of seven Asian churches under John, representing the contemplative life.²⁰

In the *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, Joachim identifies five "general orders" of the Church

17. "Multiplex in involutum Scripturarum mysterium, et veluti de altera forma in alteram, ac si cera liquida commutatur." *Expos.* ff. 107^{vb}-108^{ra}, translated by McGinn in *The Calabrian Abbot*.

18. "apertum est sepulchrum littere et apparuit spiritualis intelligentia." *Expos.* f. 153^{vb}.

19. Joachim's emphasis upon the knowledge in the path of salvation may appear similar to that of early Christian gnosticism. However, nothing could really be further from Joachim's conception of *intellectus spiritualis*. "Gnostic" knowledge is generally esoteric and reveals knowledge of identity, the "whence" and the "whither" of human destiny. Joachim's knowledge, on the other hand, is progressively revealed and thus open (sooner or later) to all. In addition, *intellectus spiritualis* is given by the Holy Spirit as the means by which one comes to grasp the mysteries of God. It is a knowledge, not of one's divine "spark," but of growing intimacy with God. While Joachim's focus upon exegesis and his rich symbolic images may strike one as esoteric, they are in fact the expression of a rather orthodox vision of salvation.

20. *Ench.*, 80.

corresponding to the five "times" in the history of the second *status*, i.e. the history of the Church. The order of prelates came first and resisted the synagogue. Then came the martyrs, who resisted the pagans. The doctors debated the heretics. The virgins contended with the Moslems. Finally, the Roman church resists Babylon. As world history moves into the third *status* and the sixth "time" with the opening of the sixth seal, Joachim prophesied that two new orders of spiritual men would operate in the transitional period, bringing the number of orders to seven, i.e. perfection. These *virī spirituales* will combat the "unholy trinity" of the dragon from Revelations 12 and the two great beasts from Revelations 13. Victorious in this conflict, the Church would reach a place in history, on earth, where it would be at peace and at rest in the fullness of *intelligentia spiritualis*. The progress of the Church in history, from the second status to the third, from the imperfection of the five orders to the perfection in seven, from the literal understanding to the spiritual, form the program for an apocalyptic mystical path.

Joachim's apocalypticism is distinct and, we can argue, more "mystical" than other apocalyptic thought in his focus on Scriptural understanding. Joachim's emphasis upon spiritual exegesis locates him in a mystical-exegetical tradition that begins in the Christian world with Origen. Bernard McGinn has noted, together with Patricia Cox, that "Origen's 'theological poesis' is an exegetical process in which religious experience, especially mystical experience, is realized in the act of making the language of the Bible at its deepest and incommunicable level into the soul's language."²¹ This can safely be said of Joachim's *intellectus spiritualis*, as well. For Joachim, this act of translation, or perhaps, "transformation" becomes possible with Christ, and it is not fully realized until the third *status*. Its gradual revelation is part of an apocalyptic progress into total contemplation. Joachim's theology of history thus interprets the sweeping world-historical schema of apocalyptic eschatology in the light of mystical theology. Fifty-some years after his death, Bonaventure would appropriate and adapt this insight in his own theology of history.

B. Bonaventure

Bonaventure employs Joachim's theology of history judiciously. His very deliberate emphasis of certain aspects of Joachim's thought and de-emphasis of others reveal his attempt to moderate the claims of some of the "spiritual" Franciscans allied with the previous Minister General.²² Bonaventure's theology of history is clearly Joachimist; his use of the "double-seven" schema of history, the concept of a *novus ordo* coming in the future age, and the idea of the realization of the Heavenly Jerusalem in history come directly from the Calabrian abbot. At the same time, Bonaventure speaks cautiously of Joachim's trinitarian division of history and rejects the pseudo-Joachite belief in

21. Bernard McGinn, *The Foundations of Mysticism* (New York: Crossroad, 1991), 116.

22. For the details of this controversy, see Malcolm Lambert, *Franciscan Poverty: The Doctrine of the Absolute Poverty of Christ and the Apostles in the Franciscan Order 1210-1323*, revised ed. (St. Bonaventure: Franciscan Institute, 1998), 109-148.

the "eternal evangel" surpassing the New Testament. This careful use of Joachim is explicated primarily in his last work, the *Collationes in Hexaëmeron*. This last and incomplete work offers a Bonaventurian theology of history that is artful both in its synthetic ingenuity and in its attempt to codify a moderate, orthodox, but distinctively Franciscan perspective.

The *Collationes* expound a theology of history structured loosely around an allegorical interpretation of the six days (*hexaëmeron*) of creation and the seventh, the sabbath. For the seven days, Bonaventure identifies seven levels of knowledge (or "visions") and seven stages (*tempora* or *aetates*, alternately) of history. Like Joachim, Bonaventure emphasizes two dispensations, the Old and New Testaments, and thus arrives at a double-seven configuration for the ages of history: seven in the Old Testament, seven in the New.²³ In sum, then, the history of the created world turns around three sets of seven which form a Trinitarian unity of origin, exemplarity, and grace or salvation. The seven days of creation are the time of origin. The seven times of the Old Testament, from Adam to Christ, are the times of exemplarity. Finally, the history of the Church, from Christ to the present, is the age of grace. This threefold understanding is one of the ways Bonaventure defines a broad trinitarian understanding of history, and it is clearly not the trinitarian division of Joachim. In fact, Bonaventure's schema reduces more or less to the twofold division of the "double sevens" with the addition of an originary week that is really ahistorical. Bonaventure hesitates to endorse the three-*status* periodization of history.

Bonaventure deliberately draws away from Joachim on this point. In the seventy years since his death, Joachim's doctrine of the "third *status*" had been interpreted by Gerardo di Borgo San Donnino and others to mean that the New Testament is surpassed and that the work of Christ is superseded by the work of the Holy Spirit. Bonaventure rejects this understanding and thus does not adopt Joachim's doctrine. Bonaventure's theology always revolves around the exemplary figure of Christ; any diminishment of the role of Christ is anathema to his thought.

As Zachary Hayes has attested, the image of Christ as center of the world dominates Bonaventure's thought:

Bonaventure is convinced that there is a center of meaning and intelligibility in the world around which our personal lives must be built. It is the tragedy of sin that it has made the world almost illegible. The center, which exists at the heart of reality, has become hidden from our view. The figure of the poor, humble loving, suffering Christ provides the concrete revelation of the center which would otherwise remain hidden.²⁴

If this is true generally, for his theological project as a whole, so is it true specifically for his theology of history. Bonaventure begins the first *Collatio* with an exhortation to focus upon Christ as center.

[One] ought to begin from the center [*a medio*], which is Christ. For he himself is the

23. *Collatio* XVI. See outline, Appendix 1, taken from Ratzinger, p. 21.

24. Zachary Hayes, *The Hidden Center: Spirituality and Speculative Christology in St. Bonaventure* (St. Bonaventure: Franciscan Institute, 1992 [reprint]) 51.

mediator between God and human, holding the center in everything . . . Our intent, then, is to show that in Christ are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge, and that he himself is the center of all understanding.²⁵

Bonaventure exhorts his students to follow the path of prudence in their pursuit of knowledge in any discipline. The theology of history is no exception. For Bonaventure, history turns around the Incarnation; the spiritual meaning of the course of events becomes intelligible only in relation to the concrete, historical revelation of Christ. Bonaventure's reading of Joachim thus emphasizes his "double seven" schema and folds the trinitarian division into a subordinate, but more explicitly mystical, hermeneutic for the history of the Church.²⁶

Bonaventure's seven ages of the Church, the "second half" of history, very much follows Joachim's *Expositio in Apocalypsim*. From Christ and the apostles to Pope Clement I (ca. 99 C.E.) was the time of "gathering grace," when Christ formed the Church and it became separated from the synagogue. The second *tempus*, from Clement to Silvester (ca. 335 C.E.), was the age of martyrs ending with the peace of Constantine. From Silvester to Leo (ca. 461 C.E.), was the time of doctors, when the Church was afflicted with heresies. The fourth time, from Leo to Gregory the Great (ca. 604 C.E.) was the time of law, where canon law, the political order of the Church, and the monastic rule all were born. The time of the "sublime See" brought the victory of the Roman Patriarch over the Greeks in the fifth period. Finally, the sixth *tempus*, in which Bonaventure places himself, is marked by three distinctive victories: the political triumph of Charlemagne which yields peace to the Church, the intellectual accomplishment of the Carolingian scholars which brings forth the "clarity of doctrine," and the dawn of prophetic action in the mendicant orders. The sixth age will also be characterized by persecution of the Church. The seventh age, to be treated in greater depth later, is an historical realization of the "sabbath rest". . . a time of peace and spiritual understanding.²⁷ Bonaventure's appropriation of Joachim's seven ages of the Church hardly strays from the Calabrian abbot's example.

But Bonaventure is no parrot. His innovative interpretive move takes shape in his application of a classic mystical program to the progressive movement of the Church in history. A good scholastic of the thirteenth century, Bonaventure was influenced greatly by the "rediscovery" of the thought of [pseudo] Dionysius the Areopagite. His theology of history bears the imprint of this influence, as Joseph Ratzinger has illustrated in far greater detail than this paper will allow.²⁸ For our purposes, the

25. " . . . *Incipiendum est a medio, quod est Christus. Ipse enim mediator Dei et hominum est, tenens medium in omnibus, . . . Propositum igitur nostrum est ostendere, quod in Christo sunt omnes thesauri sapientiae et scientiae Dei absconditi, et ipse est medium omnium scientiarum.*" *Collatio* I.10-11.

26. Ratzinger and Delio believe that this opposes Bonaventure to Joachim; I believe that McGinn and Reeves have shown that Joachim's christology cannot be so easily dismissed.

27. *Collatio* XVI. 18-29.

28. Ratzinger, Chapter III.

elements leading to the contemplative age are most relevant. Dionysius envisions creation as the circular process of descent from the divine and ascent to it in the form of neoplatonic hierarchies of being. Bonaventure's *Itinerarium mentis in Deum*, written shortly after his appointment as Minister General, forged the Dionysian hierarchies of ascent into the foundation of his mystical theology. The *Collationes in Hexaëmeron*, written near the end of his career, represent Bonaventure's broadened application of the mystical vision of the *Itinerarium* to the historical mission of the Church. Bonaventure thoroughly historicizes Dionysius's cosmological order,²⁹ such that the Church Militant represents temporally the mystical ascent to God. In effect, he "tips over" the Dionysian cosmology to fashion a historical eschatology.³⁰

Bonaventure identifies nine stages of *exercitia*, or "practice," corresponding to the nine levels of the Dionysian celestial hierarchy and grouped in three groups of three. The first triplet, corresponding to the Father, is that of the active life. Angels, Archangels, and Principalities represent the common people, consuls, and princes in the hierarchy, respectively. Together they constitute the "Order of the Laity" which lives the active life. The "Clerical Order" lives the *vita permixta* (mixed life) which corresponds to the Son. The ministerial, priestly, and pontifical offices correspond to the hierarchy's Powers, Virtues, and Dominations in this stage. Finally, the contemplative life corresponds to the Holy Spirit and is lived out by the "Monastic Order." Those in the Monastic Order "attend to the divine in three ways: through supplication, through speculation, and through ascending (*sursumactivum*)."³¹ Those in supplication are the Thrones; those in speculation, the Cherubim. Those who "move upwards" or ascend through ecstasy and rapture are the Seraphic order, and ". . . in them the Church will be consummated."³² With an apocalyptic twist, Bonaventure adds that these Seraphic people "will not flourish unless Christ appears and suffers in his mystical body."³³ The Church thus proceeds from the active life of the Father, through the mixed life of the Son, to its "consummation" in contemplative ecstasy of the Holy Spirit in a fixed apocalyptic progression.

Like Joachim's controversial trinitarian interpretation of history, Bonaventure's triune "historical hierarchy" does not signify a strict periodization; rather, it represents growth in spiritual, mystical knowledge. The three "orders" overlap, and none have disappeared entirely. At the same

29. Ratzinger 92.

30. That is, he takes the Dionysian hierarchies, which are usually perceived as vertical (hence the language of ascent, the image of ladders, etc.), and applies them horizontally -- as achieved in the chronological sequence of history. Of course, this, too, is an ascent insofar as it is a return to God, so the terms should not be taken too strongly.

31. "*Intendunt autem divinis tripliciter: quidam per modum supplicatorium, quidam per modum speculatorium, quidam per modum sursumactivum.*" *Collatio* XXII.20.

32. "*Et in his consummabitur Ecclesia.*" *Collatio* XXII.22.

33. "*Iste ordo non flebit, nisi Christus appareat et patiatur in corpore suo mystico.*" *Collatio* XXII.23.

time, Bonaventure's schema is clearly a progressive historical revelation. Even within the monastic order, the movement from the way of supplication, found in the Benedictine, Cistercian, and Carthusian lives, to the way of speculation, found in the "minors and preachers," is historical. The mendicant life is the most recent path to the revelation of divine things. Bonaventure's trinitarian revelation in *exeritia* is thus historical, but not strictly linear.³⁴

Nevertheless, the end of this revelation is clear. Bonaventure attributes a unique role in history to the founder of his Order, Francis of Assisi. In the *Legenda maior*, Bonaventure extolls the virtues of Francis with apocalyptic enthusiasm:

In these last times the grace of God our Savior has dawned in his servant Francis on all who are truly humble and love poverty. . . God forestalled him by the gift of His divine grace, so that he won the praise of heroic virtue. Then he was filled with the spirit of prophecy and charged with the ministry of Angels, as he burned with the flames of a love worthy of the Seraphim. . . Therefore there is every reason to believe that it is he who is referred to under the image of an Angel coming up from the east, with the seal of the living God, in the prophecy of another friend of Christ the bridegroom, St. John the Apostle and Evangelist. St. John tells us in the Apocalypse, "I saw a second Angel coming up from the east, with the seal of the living God."³⁵

The *Collationes* echo the identification of Francis with the Angel of the sixth seal; in fact, in placing Francis within the broader context of history, they shed additional light on his significance. In Bonaventure's system of seven, Francis is the one who initiates the prophetic life in the Church:

For it was necessary that there would be one order [community, way of life], a prophetic disposition like the the order [community, way of life] of Jesus Christ, whose head would be the 'angel ascending from the rising sun'. . . and he [Bonaventure] said that this one had already come.³⁶

This "prophetic presence" similar to Jesus' way of life is never explicitly explained by Bonaventure; yet, it seems probable that Bonaventure, as a good Franciscan, refers here to Francis's ideal life of perfect poverty. Francis is the prophet of the apostolic poverty that will characterize the spiritual

34. Bonaventure's fusion of Joachim's trinitarian history of revelation with the Dionysian hierarchies constitutes a deliberate mitigation of more rigorous historical claims made by Joachites like Gerardo di Borgo San Donnino. Fitting the growth of spiritual understanding into a broader cosmological vision of procession and return which still centers on Christ has the effect of decentering the doctrine of the third status, such that the trinitarian attributions are almost footnotes to the hierarchical nine.

35. *Legenda maior*, in *St. Francis of Assisi, Omnibus of Sources*, Marion Habig, ed. (Chicago: Franciscan Herald Press, 1973), 631-632. On the apocalyptic dimensions of this work, see Richard K. Emmerson and Ronald B. Herzman, *The Apocalyptic Imagination in Medieval Literature* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania, 1992) 34-75.

36. "Et necesse fuit, ut in hoc tempore veniret unus ordo, scilicet habitus propheticus, similis ordini Iesu Christi, cuius caput esset **Angelus ascendens ab ortu solis**. . . -Et dixit, quod iam venerat." *Collatio XVI*.16.

church.

Similarly, Francis is the one and only example cited by Bonaventure of the Seraphic order. As such, Francis experienced the ecstatic rapture of mystical knowledge of God. The apparition of the Seraph to Francis at Alverna is for Bonaventure the first dispensation of the "consummation of the Church" as noted above. Francis stands at a turning point of history, at once initiating the prophetic life of the penultimate age of history and standing already at the consummation point beckoning the Church to follow. He is the mystagogue of the last times, an apocalyptic Beatrice leading the Church through persecution into spiritual understanding and contemplation.

Whether this means that the Friars Minor themselves are intended to be the Seraphic people is a disputed question. Ratzinger argues persuasively that there is a clear and qualitative distinction between the Franciscans and the "ordo ultimus." Based upon the distinction made above between Cherubic and Seraphic contemplation, he argues that Francis is to be the "head" of two orders. . . first the Franciscans, the "empirical order", then the final "eschatological order." According to Bonaventure, the full harvest of Francis's ideal is not possible in the sixth age; it must wait for the seventh.³⁷ I find Ratzinger's argument on this point almost entirely persuasive. However, he may draw his distinction too strictly.

At the end of *Collatio XX*, Bonaventure explicitly connects poverty and contemplation in his discussion of the ideal of contemplation as a promised land. "Contemplation cannot exist except in the greatest simplicity, and greatest simplicity cannot be except in the highest poverty. And this is proper of this order. The intention of the Blessed Francis was to live in the highest poverty."³⁸ True contemplation, then, is the Franciscan ideal. He continues: "Since we have fallen back from our state, God has allowed us to be afflicted, that we may be led back to that state which ought to hold the Promised Land."³⁹ This text's discussion of fall and return would seem to indicate that, for Bonaventure, the Franciscan Order was to have been the "Seraphic order" possessed of perfect poverty and ecstatic rapture. And, through the suffering of affliction, the Order shall return to that true poverty and thus enjoy that rapture. Although Bonaventure has already made it clear that the "Friars and the Preachers" constitute the Cherubic order,⁴⁰ if we think of the nine stages, not as epochs, but as stages of historical growth, it is conceivable that the Friars Minor, purified through suffering, could pass from Cherub to Seraph and into the seventh Age. Ratzinger is right to point out that the

37. Ratzinger 50-54.

38. "*Contemplatio non potest esse nisi in summa simplicitate, et summa simplicitas non potest esse nisi in maxima paupertate, et haec est huius ordinis. Intentio beati Francisci fuit esse in summa paupertate.*" *Collatio XX*.30.

39. "*Et dicebat, quoniam multum retrocessimus a statu nostro, et ideo permittit nos Deus affligi, ut per hoc reducamur ad statum, qui debet habere terram promissionis.*" *Collatio XX*.30.

40. *Collatio XXI*.33.

Friars have not attained their goal. Bonaventure is surely no "spiritual." Nevertheless, I believe Ratzinger errs in failing to draw greater continuity between the "empirical" Franciscans and the "eschatological" Order of Francis. The difference between them is not of kind but of degree. The tenor of the above passage would seem to accuse the spirituals not of outright error but of arrogance. Always conservative, ever moderate, Bonaventure did not teach that the Friars Minor were the heralds of the seventh age of the Church. But neither did he deny that they someday could be.

In sum, the course of history is for Bonaventure the mystical ascent to God. The *Collationes in Hexaëmeron* fuse the Joachite insight into the "fullness of history," the Dionysian method of hierarchical ascent, and the uniquely Franciscan hagiographical understanding of Francis of Assisi into a comprehensive theology of history. It is the Seraphic Doctor's particular genius to synthesize these disparate strands into a theology that not only coheres, but also mitigates the claims to eschatological significance of the "spiritual" wing and offers a moderate defense of Joachimist eschatology. The *Collationes* represent Bonaventure's attempt as both scholar and Minister General of his order to codify an orthodox Franciscan theology of history.

As we have seen, however, Bonaventure's best efforts to unify the Order of Friars Minor under a moderate banner ultimately failed. The followers of Francis had dispersed across too broad a theological spectrum to be reconciled, and at Bonaventure's death, the "spiritual" and "conventual" wings of the order were still at odds. From the ranks of the "spiritual" wing, Peter Olivi emerged as an articulate spokesman, a scholarly voice for their radical, rigorous interpretation of Francis and his apostolic poverty. Olivi's *Lectura super Apocalypsim* reveal an eschatological consciousness of his order and its tribulations as the crucible of the seventh and last age of the history of the Church.

C. Peter Olivi

Olivi's method is largely derivative of both Joachim and Bonaventure. He divides history into the now-familiar double-seven and threefold patterns. He identifies the sixth and seventh ages of church history with the dawn of the third age, the age of the Holy Spirit. With Bonaventure, he attributes special significance to Francis of Assisi in the dawn of the sixth age, and he understands evangelical poverty to bound inexorably to the *intellectus spiritualis* of the spiritual Church. Olivi's original contribution to this line of thought derives from his sense of immediacy in the apocalyptic timetable. This sense of imminent crisis pervades his *Lectura super Apocalypsim* and makes his reading of the "signs of the time" unique.

Olivi's seven-stage history of the Church begins to unfold much in the way we have seen in Joachim and Bonaventure. The first stage was that of apostles; the second, martyrs; the third, doctors. Olivi's fourth stage is slightly modified: where Joachim had set the "virgins" against the Moslems and Bonaventure saw the triumph of "law," Olivi marks it as the age of anchorites who resist the hypocrites. This modification tips the hand of the radical Franciscan and offers a glance at his general historical hermeneutic. If salvation history for Joachim is the history of exegesis, it is the history of the struggle for the "evangelical life" in Olivi's eyes. The course of events in the Church all can be seen as the struggle to maintain and expand the *vita apostolica* of Christ and his disciples.

This hand is played out further as Olivi characterizes the fifth age of Church history. Bonaventure's fifth time had begun in Gregory the Great's papacy, and had been an age of papal triumph. In contrast, Olivi's fifth time begins with the rise of the Frankish empire.⁴¹ The Church of the fifth age has undergone a *condescensio*, a "falling away" from the way of Christ.

Drawing away from faithful worship, from the pure love and the delights of Spouse, Christ of God, she [the Church] clings to this world, its delights and its wealth, and thus to the devil. She clings to the kings and magnates, the prelates, and all the other loves of this world.⁴²

The Church has become a whore. In fact, she has become **the** whore of Babylon of Revelations 17. In sacrificing rigor for worldly comprehension, the Church has decayed until "around the end of the fifth period practically the whole Church is infected from head to toe, confused, and turned into a new Babylon, as it were."⁴³ Note the use of the present tense: Olivi places his present situation at the end of the fifth period, when the carnal Church dominates the ecclesiastical landscape.

But in the midst of this prevalent *condescensio*, Peter Olivi sees spiritual renewal and regeneration signaling the birth of the sixth age as well. Olivi's sixth age began prophetically in the revelations of Joachim of Fiore and his followers. Then, with the Rule of Francis, it was established and began to grow. Finally, the sixth age will be spread by the preaching of spiritual men (read "Franciscans") and will come to fruition when Babylon, the carnal Church, has been destroyed.⁴⁴ Then at last will the reign of the spiritual church come about in the seventh age.

Olivi sees his own time as the crucial breaking point between the second and third status of history. The first five ages of the Church were of the second status, and will yield to a new spiritual Church of the third status. The transition from the fifth to the sixth is the crucial rupture in the history of the Church, the point of radical transformation from the carnal loves to a renewed evangelical life. Francis plays the vital role in this transition. In "renovating" the evangelical life, Francis of Assisi acts as an *alter Christus*, a "second Christ,"⁴⁵ creating as radical a break from the Church of the first five ages as Christ's break from the synagogue:

41. *Expositio in Apocalypsim* (MS Rome, Bibl. Ang. 382) ff.46^{vb}, 51^{vb}, 93^{ra}. (Hereafter *Apoc*). Note that Bonaventure marks the Carolingian triumph as the beginning of the *sixth* age of history, not the fifth, and thus affirms it as a **positive** "triumph" of the Church in history. Olivi's opinion is clearly quite different.

42. "... a fideli cultu et a sincero amore et deliciis dei christi sponsi sui recedens adheret huic seculo et deliciis et divitiis eius et dyabolo propter ista et etiam regibus et magnantibus et prelatibus et omnibus aliis amatoribus huius mundi. . ." Tocco, excerpted Chapter 17 of *Lectura super Apocalypsim*, p.40.

43. *Apoc.* f. 7^{rb}. translation taken from Burr 1976, 18.

44. *Apoc.* 52^{va-vb}.

45. See Stanislao da Campagnola, *L'Angelo del sesto sigillo e l' 'alter Christus'* (Rome, 1971) for development of the idea of Francis as *alter Christus*.

The sixth age will always be described as notably surpassing the first five and like the end of the earlier age and the beginning of a new, departing from that old age like the age of Christ left behind the old testament and the old state of the human race.⁴⁶

Francis's role is not to bring a new revelation; rather, he brings the revelation of Christ to fulfillment in the perfect imitation of the apostolic life.⁴⁷ Olivi says of Francis that "he resembled Christ as a wax figure resembles the seal that impresses it."⁴⁸ He goes so far as to suggest that Francis will imitate Christ even in Resurrection:

I have heard from a spiritual man, a man very worthy of faith who was a friend of Brother Leo, confessor and companion to Saint Francis, something consonant with the scripture which I neither assert nor know nor think ought to be asserted, namely that he discovered, both from Brother Leo and from revelation given to himself, that in the moment of Babylonian temptation, when the [Franciscan] state and rule is being crucified after the pattern of Christ, Francis will arise in glory in order that, just as he was assimilated to Christ in his life and stigmata, so he will be assimilated to him in resurrection. This will be necessary to confirm and inform his disciples, just as Christ's resurrection was necessary to confirm the apostles and inform them regarding the foundation and governance of the church.⁴⁹

Olivi is hesitant to assert this as a matter of doctrine, but, even so, his willingness to identify Francis with Christ in some fashion certainly exceeds Bonaventure's, and indeed exceeds most of his contemporaries.

The passage quoted above points as well to the special role played by Olivi's brother friars in the Franciscan Order. For Olivi, the Friars Minor are the apostles of the new age of the Holy Spirit. In David Burr's turn of phrase, they are the "shock troops of the new age,"⁵⁰ ushering in the new age and the new spiritual church. Their life of apostolic poverty and the contemplation of Christ which comes with it will flourish in both the sixth and the seventh ages of history. Olivi believed in total

46. Döllinger, ed. "Auszüge aus des Petrus Johannes d'Olive Postille über die Apocalypse," p. 527.

47. Burr 1976, 18.

48. *Apoc.* 55^{vb}.

49. "*Audiui etiam a viro spirituali valde fide digno et fratri Leoni confessori et socio beato Francisci valde familiari quoddam huic scripture consonum, quod nec assero nec scio nec censeo asserendum, scilicet quod tam per verba fratris Leonis quam per propriam revelationem sibi factam, perceperat Franciscum in illa pressura temptationes babilonicae, in qua eius status et regula quasi instar Christi crucifigetur, resurget gloriosus, ut sicut in vita et in crucis stigmatibus est Christo singulariter assimilatus, sic et in resurrectione Christo assimiletur, necessaria tunc suis discipulis confirmandis et informandis, sicut Christi resurrectio fuit necessaria apostolis confirmandis et super fundatione et gubernatore future ecclesie informandis.*" *Apoc.* 55^{rb}. Translation by David Burr in "Olivi, Apocalyptic Expectation, and Visionary Experience," *Traditio* XLI (Fordham University Press, 1985), 276.

50. Burr 1976, 23.

continuity between the way of life of his Franciscan Order and the apostolic life of the seventh age; after a time of persecution, the Franciscans would emerge as the leaders of the spiritual church. "To this order is given power and discretion for ruling the Church of that time."⁵¹ Olivi's own time, when poverty was under attack and Aristotelian philosophy was being debated, was the beginning of that time of persecution, the purifying apocalyptic path to contemplation.

Peter Olivi, like Joachim of Fiore and Bonaventure before him, saw in the apocalyptic course of history the path to contemplation and knowledge of God that the Church will inevitably tread. Common to these three interpretations of the path are the numerical schema of the double-seven periodization and the trinitarian development of spiritual growth. This spiritual growth would consist of growing *intellectus spiritualis*, tied closely to the scriptures. All three thinkers believed that they stood at the threshold of a turning point in history, when this spiritual understanding would come to fruition. The Church will face a moment of apocalyptic crisis from which it will emerge purified and prepared for the shared contemplation of God. Joachim, Bonaventure, and Olivi thus shared a basic understanding of the history and future of the Church.

But these heuristic similarities in no way obscure the differences between the Abbot, the Doctor, and the "Spiritual." Joachim of Fiore was a monk; his understanding of the development of history is essentially a growth in monastic observance. St. Bonaventure was a Franciscan and a man of the Church. His interpretation of the development of the Church in history is essentially continuous, the passage of the whole Church through stages of mystical ascent, beckoned on by Francis and his ideal. Peter Olivi was a reformer and thus a Franciscan of a different stripe; for him, Francis ruptured the continuity of Church history by renovating the apostolic life of Christ. Olivi's apocalyptic turning point is imminent; his spiritual church is at hand. All three thinkers interpreted history as the path of the Church toward mystical contemplation of God, but, as we have seen, the nature of the path differed for each. Consequently, each thinker's vision of the consummation of that path in the fullness of the third *status* and seventh age of history is somewhat unique. It is to that consummation that we now turn.

III. The "Disposition" of the Contemplative Age

Our journey with Joachim, Bonaventure, and Olivi through their historical paths of the Church has brought us to the consummation of those paths, and thus to the culmination of this essay. In the introduction, I highlighted an interpretive strategy consisting of two questions. The above section is the result of the first question, "Where is the mystical element in the apocalyptic course of history?" My task in this section of the paper is to examine the last question in two dimensions: How does the eschatological culmination of history disclose its mystical dimension? And how is the social character of this mystical dimension described? I have already alluded to the significance of *intellectus spiritualis* as a defining characteristic of the contemplative age, but I must now examine it in detail.⁵²

51. "Huic ordini prefato datur potestas et discretio regendi ecclesiam illius temporis." *Apoc.* f. 75^{ra}.

52. My task shall not be to outline the many and various complexities contained within Joachim's exegetical strategies. A

Further, I will analyze the social and institutional structures of the Church in the future age. In both aspects, Joachim, Bonaventure, and Olivi use mystical categories to interpret the coming *ecclesia spiritualis*.

For Joachim of Fiore, the fullness of the Scriptures will be revealed in the third *status*. As we have noted, *intellectus spiritualis* was born in the resurrection of Jesus, when "the tomb of the letter was opened."⁵³ Since that time, it has continued to develop in the second *status*, but it is found infrequently in a few individuals. The autobiographical fragments Joachim leaves in his writings contain elements that seem to indicate that he considered himself one of those few.⁵⁴ In the *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, he recounts one of those visions:

Having gone through the preceding verses of the Apocalypse to this place, I experienced such a great difficulty and mental constraint beyond the ordinary that it was like feeling the stone that closed the tomb oppose me. . . . Since I was involved in many things, forgetfulness led the matter far away. After a year, the feast of Easter came around. Awakened from sleep about midnight, something happened to me as I was meditating on this book, something for which, relying on God's gift, I am made bold to write. . . . Since some of the mysteries were already understood, but the greater mysteries were still hidden, there was a kind of struggle going on in my mind. . . . Then, on the above-mentioned night, something like this happened. About the middle of the night's silence, as I think, the hour when it is thought that our Lion of the Tribe of Judah rose from the dead, as I was meditating, suddenly something of the fullness of book of this book and of the entire harmony of the Old and New Testaments was perceived with the clarity of understanding in my mind's eye. The revelation was made when I was not even mindful of the chapter mentioned above.⁵⁵

comprehensive treatment can already be found in McGinn's *Calabrian Abbot*, Chapter 4. Anything I could offer would be entirely derivative of this. My purpose, rather, is to highlight aspects of the *experience* of spiritual understanding, not the way to it.

53. "*apertum est sepulchrum littere*. . ." *Expos.* f. 153^{vb}.

54. See Reeves and Hirsch-Reich 1972, 10-11. They argue that "Joachim believed his spiritual experience was representative of a general experience to come. It was for all men that the spirit was sepulchred in *ventre littere* and for all men that 'the sepulchre of the letter would be opened and the spiritual intelligence appear.'"

55. "*Et enim cum decursis precentibus libri huius capitulis pervenirem ad locum istum tantam fateor difficultatem, et quasi preter solitum perpersus sum angustias intellectus ut sentiens oppositum mihi lapidem ab ostio monumenti . . . Cumque me occupatum in multis hoc ipsum oblivio procul duceret; factum est verso anni circulo diem adesse paschalem, mibique circa horam matutinam excitato a somno aliquid in libro isto meditati occurrere pro quo confisus de dono Dei audacior factus sum ad scribendum . . . et enim cum nonnullam capere, et maiora adhuc sacramenta nescirem, quasi quedam pugna gerebatur in mente mea . . . Cum ergo in supra scripta nocte simile aliquid contigisset. Circa medium (ut opinor) noctis silentium et horam qua leo noster de tribu iuda resurrexisse extimatur a mortuis, subito mihi meditati aliquid quadam mentis oculi intelligentie claritate percepta de plenitudine libri huius et tota veteris ac novi testamenti concordia. Revelatio facta est, et*

This rich passage offers several clues toward understanding the nature of *intellectus spiritualis*. First, the revelation is bound to scripture. Joachim's understanding comes after an intellectual "struggle" over a verse by which he feels "constrained"; the letter of scripture binds his understanding. His vision allows him to break through that letter into the freedom of the spirit. Joachim's vision in fact reflects in miniature the historical progression of the Church in spiritual understanding. Joachim stands at a place where "some of the mysteries were already understood, but the greater mysteries were still hidden," as someone of the second *status* would. Partially freed from the fetters of the letter, Joachim struggles toward total understanding of the "mysteries" of the spirit, a fullness characteristic of the third *status*. Joachim thus presents himself as a sort of exemplar in the transition from the second to the third *status*, traversing the path in his vision that the entire Church pursues in history.

Implicit in the vision is the centrality of Christ as the model for his "breakthrough." As Joachim is "awakened from sleep" on Easter morning, having struggled against the "stone" of a difficult verse, his sudden revelation comes as a kind of *imitatio Christi*. The spiritual understanding of the third *status* never abandons or surpasses Christ; instead, it imitates his resurrection. The age of the Holy Spirit simply brings this Christocentric understanding to perfect fulfillment. Joachim believes that spiritual understanding was fulfilled in a few (the apostles) at the time of Pentecost, but it is to be consummated "after the newest day of the age [the third *status*] in all the saints."⁵⁶ There is thus no discontinuity between the quality of the spiritual understanding of the third *status* and that of the second; Joachim's revelations are a true foretaste of what is to come for all in the future age of the Holy Spirit.

Another autobiographical fragment in the *Psalterium decem chordarum* highlights the role of the Spirit in Joachim's spiritual understanding:

I was very frightened [by doubts about the Trinity] and was moved to call on the Holy Spirit (whose feast day it was) to deign to show me the holy mystery of the Trinity. The Lord promised us that the whole understanding of truth is to be found in the Trinity . . . At this moment, without delay, the shape of a ten-stringed psaltery appeared in my mind. The mystery of the Holy Trinity shone so brightly and clearly in it that I was at once impelled to cry out, "What God is as great as our God?"⁵⁷

Joachim's invocation of the Holy Spirit on her feast ties the third person to the "whole understanding of truth" he seeks. It is no accident that Joachim's two glimpses of spiritual understanding occur on

nec sic recordatus sum suprascripti capituli. . . Expos. f. 39^{r-v}. Translated by Bernard McGinn in *Visions of the End*, 130.

56. "*Quod autem in die Pentecostes consummatum est in apostolis, post novissimum diem saeculi consummandum est in omnibus sanctis.*" Ench. f. 38^v.

57. ". . . et conterritus vehementer compulsus sum invocare Spiritum Sanctum cuius sacra solemnitas presens erat ut ipse mihi dignaretur ostendere sacrum mysterium Trinitatis, in quo nobis promissa est a Bomino omnis notitia veritatis. . . .Nec Mora occurrit animo modo forma psalterii decachordi et in ipsa tam lucidum et apertum sacre mysterium Trinitatis ut protinus compellerer clamare, *Quis deus magnus sicut deus noster?*" Psalt. f. 227^{r-v}. Again, translation of Bernard McGinn in *Apocalyptic Spirituality*, 99.

Easter, the feast of Christ's resurrection, and Pentecost, the feast of the Holy Spirit. In these two visions, Joachim pays tribute to the two divine processions from the Father who are the principles of spiritual understanding. *Intellectus spiritualis* originates in Christ and is fulfilled in the Spirit.

The fulfillment of Joachim's vision here is not an unmediated "pure knowledge." It still comes to him through an image, but it is an image in which knowledge "shone so brightly and clearly" within it. With spiritual understanding, images do not mask mysteries; they demonstrate their truth. The ten-stringed psaltery is a didactic tool by which God conveys truth to Joachim, and Joachim, in turn, uses it to illustrate his thought in the book that follows. For the abbot, spiritual understanding is not the abolition of images or mysteries; instead, it is the ability to understand clearly and immediately the truth contained in them. This revelation of truth is so immediate, so brilliant, and so clear, that it issues forth in ecstatic utterance, "What God is as great as our God?" Hardly a dry intellectual experience. Joachim's *intellectus spiritualis* is the all-encompassing consummation of the spiritual life in the third *status*.

While Bonaventure echoes Joachim's conviction that scriptural understanding is central to the coming final age of history, he does not share the Abbot's commitment to its ultimacy. Bonaventure, like Joachim, sees the spiritual understanding of Scripture developing in history. Spiritual vision, as guided by the Scriptures, has three objects: the "spiritual understanding of the senses," the "sacramental figures," and the "multiform contemplative insights."⁵⁸ The "spiritual understanding of the senses" is the traditional tripartite understanding of the allegorical, tropological, and anagogical senses of scripture. The "sacramental figures" are typological understandings that perceive in all the books of Scripture the polar opposites of Christ and Antichrist. These two are relatively traditional modes of understanding Scripture.

The third object, that of "multiform contemplative insights" is the source of the progressive development of revelation. Using the metaphor of the third day of creation, where the earth brings forth vegetation, Bonaventure compares the multiform theories to seeds:

Who can know the infinity of the seeds, when in one are contained forests upon forests and thence and infinite number of seeds? Likewise, infinite contemplative insights which none but God can understand can be drawn from Scripture. For as new seeds from plants, new interpretations and new meanings come forth from Scripture; thus is sacred Scripture distinguished [from everything else]. Hence, just as if one drop were drawn from the ocean, so are all the insights which have been drawn, in relation to those [insights] which *could* have been drawn out. [emphasis mine.]⁵⁹

58. "*spirituales intelligentias sensuum . . . sacramentales figuras . . . multiformes theorias*." *Collatio* XIII.2. "Theories" does not seem to capture Bonaventure's sense adequately. Recent work on Aristotle has shown that the Philosopher's usage of *theoria* seems to be quite close indeed to monastic uses of *contemplatio*, but 'contemplations' in the plural seemed a bit cumbersome. Hence, "contemplative insights." See Thomas W. Smith, *Revaluing Ethics: Aristotle's Dialectical Pedagogy* (New York: SUNY Press, forthcoming), especially Ch. 8.

59. "*Quis potest scire infinitatem seminum, cum tamen in uno sint silvae silvarum et postea infinita semina? Sic ex Scripturis elici possunt*

Scripture is essentially fecund. Each "theory" drawn from it contains an infinite number of additional contemplative insights within. Scriptural understanding is thus infinite, unfolding in time, never to be exhausted.

This "multiform" spiritual understanding of Scripture first appeared in the apostles and will extend into the final age of history, "flowing forth abundantly." Bonaventure says that this abundance "refers especially to the time of the New Testament, when the Scriptures were made plain, and above all in the end, when the Scriptures which simply are not understood now will be understood then." This will be the fullness of understanding in the "contemplative Church" which will put heresy to flight and enjoy a Sabbath peace.⁶⁰

But Bonaventure's spiritual understanding does not end here. Scriptural understanding is treated by Bonaventure as only a middle form of knowledge, the third "day" of creation. It is followed in the outline of the unfinished *Collationes* by vision "suspended in contemplation," which is directed toward nature; "raised by prophecy," that is, directed toward history; and "absorbed in God," the contemplation of the divine directly.⁶¹ These three types of "vision" correspond allegorically to the fourth, fifth, and sixth days of creation. They carry Scripture with them as a regulating principle but are not restricted to it. For example, the sixth vision, where the intelligence is absorbed in God, is

... that by which the soul of the contemplative approaches the ecstatic excesses of the mind, which also procure revelations and sweetness to the enraptured soul, *in the measure in which the authority and mystery of Sacred Scriptures suggest*. This is the final part of the spiritual life in this life. And through this sixth vision, the human person is made to be shaped into a "living being," after which God finally reposes the soul of the contemplative, ceasing to grant any new gift. And the soul itself, *although suffering the state of pilgrimage*, reposes in God.⁶²

Though guided and limited by Scripture, the contemplative soul enjoys the "ecstatic excesses" and "sweetness" of a revelation more immediate than that of Scripture. This state will be realized in

infinitae theoriae, quas nullus potest comprehendere nisi solus Deus. Sicut enim ex plantis nova semina; sic ex Scripturis novae theoriae et novi sensus, et ideo Scriptura sacra distinguitur. Unde sicut si una gutta de mari extrahatur; sic sunt omnes theoriae, quae eliciuntur, respectu illarum quae possunt elici." Collatio XIII.2.

60. "Et hoc potissime refertur ad tempus novi testamenti, quando Scriptura manifesta est, et maxime in fine, quando Scripturae intelliguntur, quae modo non intelligentur. Tunc erit mons, scilicet Ecclesia contemplativa; et tunc non nocebunt, quando fugient monstra haeresum sapientiae usura. Sed hodie mons Sion propter vulpes disperit, id est propter expositores verispelles et foetidos." Collatio XIII.7.

61. Note how closely this follows the progression of the *Itinerarium*.

62. "... per raptum mentis in Deum absorptae, videlicet quibus exercitiis et donis anima contemplantis appropinquat ad mentis excessum ecstaticum, quae etiam revelationes fiunt animae raptae et dulcedines, quantum sacrae Scripturae auctoritas et mysteria innuunt. Et haec est ultima pars vitae spiritualis in via. Et fit hac sexta visione homo formatus in animam viventem, postquam ultimate quiescit Deus in anima contemplantis, cessans a novorum donorum collatione; ipsaque anima, prout status viae patitur, in deo quiescit." Epilogue after Collatio XXIII.

history, the "state of pilgrimage." In the course of history, Scriptural wisdom, the *sapientia multiformis*, finally is subsumed in *sapientia nulliformis*, the apophatic union with God.⁶³ This is not to say that the revelation of the coming age makes the Holy Writ obsolete; Bonaventure offers no "eternal evangel." In fact he is adamant in rejecting any such doctrine: "After the New Testament, there will be no other, nor can any sacrament of the new law be eliminated, for this is an eternal testament."⁶⁴ Rather, Scripture is one element in the *intelligentia spiritualis* of Bonaventure's contemplative Church.

Similarly, Peter Olivi's spiritual understanding in the *ecclesia spiritualis* is not exclusively related to scriptural exegesis. The progress of scriptural understanding is definitely significant in the dawning of the sixth and seventh ages of history. Just as the mysteries of the first dispensation were revealed and illuminated at the end of that period with John the Baptist and Christ, so would the mysteries that remain in scripture become clear at the end of the New Testament period:

Note for the mysteries that just as in the evening the five loaves and two fishes were broken and multiplied by Christ, so at the end of the synagogue Christ appeared and multiplied the five books of Moses, that is, the Law, and two fishes, that is, the prophetic and historical books (which were the spice of the Law) in mystical senses; and it is believed that something similar will happen at the end of the Church with respect to both Testaments.⁶⁵

The spiritual Church to come will enjoy a further multiplication of scriptural understanding. This multiplication will not leave the scriptures behind. Just as the Christian Church keeps the books of the Old Testament, but understands them more spiritually, so in the future will the contemplative Church keep all the Scriptures while penetrating their spiritual meanings more deeply.

The depth dimension in Olivi's spiritual understanding is related to what I will call a "lived understanding" of the Scriptures. Olivi's discussion of the "renovation" of the evangelical life in Francis of Assisi and his line of argument in the *usus pauper* debate both point to his connection of the life of poverty with the right understanding of scripture. The Franciscan ideal is to follow the Gospel *sine glossa*, as one can see by the predominance of word-for-word quotes from the Gospel in Francis's rule. For Olivi, Francis, the incarnation of the "spirit of Christ," likewise "spiritually incarnated" scripture in the way of poverty.⁶⁶ In so doing, Francis initiated the coming age of history, where

63. Ratzinger Chapter II.

64. "Post novum testamentum non erit aliud; nec aliquod sacramentum novae legis subtrahi potest, quia illud testamentum eternum est." *Collatio XVI.2.*

65. "Nota pro misteriis quod sicut in vespere a Christo fracti et multiplicati sunt quinque panes et duo pisces, sic in fine synagoge quinque libros Moysi, id est, legem et duos pisces, id est, libros prophetales et historiales, qui erant in condimentum legis, Christus apparuit et in sensu mysticos multiplicavit et aliquid simile creditur facturum in fine ecclesie, respectu utriusque Testamenti." *Lectura super Matthaeum* f. 101^{va}. Excerpted text taken from the recent dissertation of Kevin Madigan, *Peter Olivi's Lectura super Mattaeum in Medieval Exegetical Context* (University of Chicago, 1992), 235. My thanks to him for his generous assistance.

scriptural understanding would continue to increase.

A hallmark of this spiritual increase will be the conjoining of *intellectus* and *affectus*. For Olivi, like many Franciscans, this union is always somewhat characteristic of contemplation in any age:

The union of our mind with God, called "contemplation" by the saints, is nothing other than the application of our intellect to God, the intellectual perception and apprehension of God, the intimate penetration of him through the fervor of our love, and the tasting of him . . . a process begun in the intellect, purified by faith, and consummated in the act of love. . . It always has joined with it a gustatory sense (*sensum degustantem*) which is called "taste." (*gustus*)⁶⁷

Olivi's works are full of references to "sweetness" and "taste" when speaking of contemplation and knowledge. For the Franciscan, the affections regulate the intellect, and only they can penetrate fully into God. But in the sixth and seventh ages, this union between intellect and affection will be more intimate, and the revelation thus all the more sweet. "The Holy Spirit will reveal itself as a fiery furnace of divine love and a wine-cellar of spiritual intoxication. . . [and] there will abound that chaste and sweet contemplation typical of monks or religious."⁶⁸

The unctuous spiritual understanding of the third age seems to have moved beyond Scripture. Indeed, Olivi looks forward to direct revelation in the dawning age. The herald of that age, the Blessed Francis, was a visionary as well a bringer of the "Life of the Gospel." With Francis as his model, Olivi anticipates a contemplative knowledge unmediated by sense experience. He notes that the blessed in heaven will need no scripture or doctrine, and he asserts that the spiritual church will realize this situation at least partly in the seventh age:

. . . the Spirit of Christ will teach them all truth through excess of contemplation, without the mystery of external voice or book. . . [This] is being fulfilled and will be fulfilled in lesser fashion (*secundum quid*) in the church militant.⁶⁹

The contemplative Church of the sixth and seventh ages will not enjoy the perfected beatific vision; this is reserved for the glory of eternity. How it will be fulfilled "in a lesser fashion" is left unresolved. In light of the emphasis on scripture above, it is unlikely that Olivi believed that Scripture would be totally abandoned before the dawn of eternal glory. But David Burr has demonstrated that, even in

66. *Apoc.* 7^{vb}.

67. "*unio mentis nostrae ad Deum, quae a sanctis 'contemplatio' dicitur, nihil aliud est, nisi intellectus nostri applicatio ad Deum; et Dei intellectualis perceptio et apprehensio, ipsiusque per amoris fervorem intima penetratio; fortisque et firma ad nostra intima eius attractio iugisque degustio; ab amore magis amicitiae quam concupiscentiae imperata; ab intellectu fide purificato inchoata et tandem in amoris secum sensum degustantem, qui gustus dicitur. . .*" *Questiones de perfectione evangelica*, q. 1. as excerpted in Burr 1976, 35.

68. *Apoc.* 31^{vb}.

69. *Apoc.* 120^{ra-rb}. Translated by David Burr in "Olivi's Apocalyptic Expectation and Visionary Experience," *Traditio* XLI (New York: Fordham University Press, 1985), 281.

his own time, Olivi was willing to entertain the possibility of contradicting scripture on the basis of visionary experience.⁷⁰ In the spiritual church, scripture is important, but certainly it has no absolute hegemony in the realm of spiritual knowledge.

As we can see, Joachim's doctrine of the growth of *intellectus spiritualis* found an eager audience in the Franciscans, but both Bonaventure and Olivi broadened it to include more than scriptural knowledge. It is perhaps ironic that one of the errors for which Joachim is often faulted is more apparent in his followers than in his own work. As we have seen, Scripture contains all knowledge for Joachim. Any revelation of the future age **must** therefore be scriptural. Bonaventure and Olivi, both Franciscan to the core, did not share the abbot's conviction. While both assert the necessity of scriptural understanding in the spiritual progress of the Church, both also look forward to a type of affective mystical union that is unmediated by knowledge of scripture or anything else.⁷¹

This distinction in no way diminishes the fact that, for all three thinkers, the apocalyptic plan of history consisted largely of a progressive development of *intellectus spiritualis*. This spiritual understanding consisted of a more and more immediate knowledge of the mysteries of God. For Joachim, this immediacy was to be found only in the unveiled mysteries of Scripture. For Bonaventure and Olivi, scriptural understanding was to be appended to affective longing for God in the perfection of contemplation. But whatever the source of this immediacy, all three men agree that it will be realized in history, when the imperfect will pass away and when God will write directly upon the hearts of the elect.

This radical immediacy implicitly questions the authority of the mediating institution of the Church. Traditionally, the hierarchical Church is the one and only source of authoritative teaching about the mysteries of God. But if in the coming age the souls of the elect "repose in God," then what need have they of sacraments? If they are to be taught directly by the "Spirit of Christ" and the mysteries of Scripture will "shine so brightly and clearly," what need have the elect of Christian doctrine? The progression of history toward spiritual understanding means for all three thinkers the dawning of an *ecclesia spiritualis*, a "spiritual" or "contemplative Church." But the constitution of this Church and its relation to the hierarchical Church of the current age is a far more delicate matter which Joachim, Bonaventure, and Olivi each address quite differently.

Joachim's view of the *ecclesia spiritualis* is often enigmatic. As we have seen, the third *status* of history dawns in the progression from exteriority to interiority, from the fetters of the letter to the freedom of the spirit. Joachim prophesies that *virī spirituales* will arise to usher in contemplative age in

70. Burr 1985. As Burr points out, Olivi was criticized sharply for his consideration of the possibility that the side-wound of Christ was inflicted prior to this death, despite the evangelist's testimony to the contrary. His consideration was based upon the vision of a "certain spiritual man."

71. I would suggest that the difference between the monk and the mendicants on this issue is a fundamental difference in theological anthropology. While for Joachim, knowledge, though by no means dry, seems to stand above affection, the Franciscans prioritize love over knowledge.

its fullness. When speaking of general matters, the Abbot is quite clear: the coming church will be more contemplative than active. But, as Ernst Benz has aptly noted,

Much more difficult than the question of the manner of the salvation of the papal Church through the coming spiritual Church is the question of its social form and way of life. The reason for this is that Joachim does not want to say anything about it.⁷²

Any model we get from Joachim in his writings must be assembled from many allusions and hints. In the *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, Joachim speaks of the contemplative Church mainly in terms of its virtues of *pax*, *concordia*, and *intellectus spiritualis*. The few details he does suggest are sketchy at best⁷³, and they emerge clearly only against the background of one of his controversial *figurae*.

The *Dispositio novi ordinis pertinens ad tertium statum ad instar superne Jerusalem* has provoked much consideration and much debate among scholars of Joachim's thought. Grundmann has read it as Joachim's concrete model for the life of the "spiritual men" in the transition from the second to the third *status*. Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich have argued to the contrary, seeing the *figura* as a geometric form which represents the life of the third *status* proper in a more symbolic fashion.⁷⁴ Bernard McGinn has proposed a moderate compromise of sorts, arguing that the *Dispositio* is, in fact, Joachim's **concrete** representation of life in the **third status**.⁷⁵

The *Dispositio novi ordinis*, or "Arrangement of the new People of God," as McGinn has translated it, is a geometric figure which suggests from one perspective a cross upon a predella, as Grundmann has noted. In another view, it resembles the four-fold extension of the "Heavenly Jerusalem" of the Apocalypse with a central "house," four "corners," and two additional "suburbs." Thus, the total number of compartments in the figure is seven, the number that represents the fulfillment of the third *status*. The figure as a whole focuses the observer's vision upon the center, the *COLUMBA* or "Dove," symbolizing the Holy Spirit. The centrality of the Dove conveys the essential character of the figure, and thus of the life it represents. The life of the *novus ordo* will be a life in the Holy Spirit, the full flowering of the third *status*.

The figure is inundated with explanatory text, much of it Scriptural and much of it mundane. The *Dispositio* seems inspired by the two scriptural passages at the top. Joachim derives the formal structure of the figure from the Apocalypse's vision of the divine worship in the Heavenly Jerusalem (Apoc 4:1-7). Four apocalyptic beasts, lion, man, calf, and eagle, are seated around the throne of God.

72. "Viel schwieriger als die Frage nach der Art der Ablösung der Papstkirche durch die kommende Geistkirche ist die Frage nach ihrer gesellschaftlichen Form und Lebenshaltung. Der Grund hierfür ist, daß Joachim darüber nichts sagen will." Ernst Benz, *Ecclesia Spiritualis* (Stuttgart: Kohlhammer, 1934), 38.

73. Joachim suggests that the spiritual church is essentially continuous with the present church of Rome in a more spiritual form.(ff. 204^{rb-va}, 220^{vb})

74. Reeves and Hirsch-Reich, 245.

75. McGinn 1985, 113.

Joachim gives the throne its own beast, the Dove, and, as we have noted, he appends two more "beasts," the dog and the sheep, bringing the number to seven. The Throne represents the Spiritual Father and those who live "according to a rule in all things." The Eagle represents those who "are afire with spiritual desire and wish to lead a contemplative life." The Man represents the scholars and "those to be taught and instructed by God." The Calf represents the laborers, who will live a life of less spiritual discipline. The Lion represents the aged and infirmed who cannot maintain the rigor of a full rule. The final two beasts are at a distance from the rest, and are thus set apart from the more or less monastic life of the other five. The Dog represent "priests and clerics" who will not live the strict rule of abstinence but still desire the common life. Finally, the Sheep represents the married laity "living a common life."⁷⁶ The *Dispositio* is thus modeled upon the worship of the Heavenly Jerusalem (as the title claims) and upon the symbolic number of the perfection of the third *status*.

The second passage, from Paul's First Letter to the Corinthians, sheds some light on the purpose for the figure. It describes the different functions of the "members" of the "body of Christ." "God put the members, each of them, into the body on purpose. If they all were one member, where would the body be? So there are indeed many members, but one body." (1 Cor. 12:19-20) This text introduces the twin themes of diversity and unity, and it is carried into the diagram by the anatomical labels assigned to each compartment. In a passage of the *Liber Concordie* concerning the days of creation, Joachim addresses diversity and unity in the Church more explicitly:

If the Christian religion be perfectly ordained and distinct for men, all in their own forms, then each form can and ought to be brought into individual houses like seven days. For if there are many mansions in the kingdom of God, for those who each have an appropriate gift from God (another, another gift, and so on), and if in this manner, there are many members in one body and all do not have the same function, how is a particular house of that religion that seeks to restrain all under one rule said to be ordained? If such a house receives only those coming to it who come together in one particular manner, according to their inclination toward a certain member of the body -- and indeed, throws out and excludes the rest -- where is unity? and where is delight?⁷⁷

Joachim here implores the Church to include the diversity of gifts and manners of life into its spiritual structure. He believes that monasteries of his own time are guilty of exclusivism. In the "new people

76. McGinn, *Apocalyptic Spirituality*, 144.

77. "*Si religio Christiana perfecte esset ordinata et distincta pro viribus in speciebus suis, possent et deberent septem iste dierum species in singulis domibus inveniri. Si enim multe mansiones sunt in regno celorum pro eo quod unusquisque proprium donum habet ex Deo, aliis quidem sic; --et si eo modo, quo multa membra sunt in uno corpore, omnia autem membra non eundem actum habent, ita sunt et in hominibus divisiones gratiarum, --quomodo ordinata esse dicitur domus aliqua religionis, que omnes sub una norma coercere contendit? Quod si illos solos recepit ad se venientes qui conveniant in unam quamlibet speciem pertinentem ad aliquod corporis membrum, alios vero abicit et excludit, ubi unitas et dilectio?*" *Lib. conc.* f. 71^{r-v}, quoted from revised text of Grundmann in Reeves and Hirsch-Reich, 238-239.

of God pertaining to the third *status*," this diversity will be incorporated into the spiritual life of the Church.

What Joachim means by "diversity," however, is not quite what we might think. Though the figure includes regular clergy and married laity, it demonstrates Joachim's essentially monastic vision of the life of spiritual perfection. The banal details of daily existence given in the texts remind the reader in tone and topic of Benedict's Rule. They describe each compartment as an "oratory" dedicated to a particular saint and directed toward a particular way of life. Each oratory is thus given a particular vocation, e.g., for contemplation, for work, or for learning, but all are essentially degrees of the monastic life. The notion of location is central to the diagram, both in its immediate presentation to the eye and in its precisely-detailed demarcation of distances. Those in the more "active" oratories, the clerics and the married laity, are set apart from the rest, the clerics by three miles, and the lay by three *stadia* more. Each oratory will live by some sort of rule or regular life, usually defined by relative rigor in monastic observances like fasting and learning, and each will live a "common life" in one house. Joachim's *Dispositio* offers a revised, more inclusive, and more diverse Rule of Benedict, showing that life in Joachim's third *status* would be, in greater and lesser degrees, a life of monastic perfection.

As a monastic way of life, the *novus ordo* retains a hierarchical orientation toward the authority of the "throne" oratory at the center. Within this oratory, the Spiritual Father "will be over all. . .; all will obey his direction and authority."⁷⁸ Also within this oratory are those who live by the rule in all things, and thus lead the rest by example. Each of the other oratories will have its own prior or abbot who will have immediate authority over its members as a sort of Vicar for the Spiritual Father. The authority of the *Dispositio* is not at all coercive, however. "The Prior will not rebuke [those within the oratory], but will entreat them like fathers and like those of the first rank who do not need compassion."⁷⁹ Authority is exercised first of all by the will of the Spiritual Father, secondly by the example of the perfect monks, and finally by the spiritual exhortation of the priors. The new People of God need not be coerced.

The internal order of the figure thus reveals a fulfilled spiritual way of life which is diverse but still monastic. It does not abandon the active life, but clearly values the contemplative life of the monk more, as the strictly observant monks dwell at the center.⁸⁰ The *novus ordo* is hierarchical in structure, its authority culminating in one Spiritual Father, but the hierarchy is not coercive. Internally, then, the *Dispositio novi ordinis pertinens ad tertium statum ad instar superne Jerusalem* portrays an ideal, inclusive, monastic way of life.

78. McGinn, *Apocalyptic Spirituality*, 144.

79. McGinn *Apocalyptic Spirituality*, 144.

80. Although we are never told explicitly that the Spiritual Father is one of these strictly-observant monks, it seems likely that he is.

How this internally coherent picture of the spiritual life of the third *status* relates to the *ecclesia spiritualis* as a whole is a disputed question. Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich interpret it as an allegorical representation of the order of the entire Church, but both Grundmann and McGinn have highlighted the specificity of the details to argue that Joachim had something more specific in mind. With the available evidence, it seems plausible that Joachim considered this *figura* to be a representative microcosm of the coming Church in the fullness of the third *status*. It is both a concrete "floorplan" for a new *ordo* of the coming age and a model of the Church as a whole. That is, in its concrete detail, it is the outline for the way of life of a particular community in the contemplative age. But, as such, it is a microcosmic instantiation of a structure that fits the macrocosm of the whole Church as well.

In the *Enchiridion super Apocalypsim*, Joachim notes that the "Heavenly Jerusalem" of the third *status* will have pastors, deacons, doctors, and contemplatives within it; the active life will not pass away.⁸¹ The *Dispositio*, too, is modeled upon the Heavenly Jerusalem and contains both the active life and the contemplative, both Peter and John. Similarly, in the *Expositio* (f. 220^{vb}), Joachim says that the Pope is Christ's vicar until His return. From these texts we can argue that Joachim's vision of the Church as a whole is like that of the *Dispositio*: inclusive, monastic, and hierarchical. Joachim's *ecclesia spiritualis* is really just that: the present Roman church "spiritualized," i.e., the Roman Church joining as a whole in the more perfect Christian life of monasticism. The hierarchical structure of the Church will not "pass away" in any real sense; rather, it will be perfected in the manner shown in miniature in the *Dispositio*. The active life of clerics and the laity will be drawn under a monastic rule; the contemplative life will rule over the active. The pope will be a "Spiritual Father" who will be "over all." Joachim's vision of the "spiritual Church" in the third *status* is but the culmination of the broader historical journey, begun in Christ, from the letter to the spirit, from exterior to interior, and from the reign of the active life to the rule of the contemplative.

Bonaventure's vision of the *ecclesia spiritualis* echoes Joachim's tone, but differs in the details. Like the Abbot of Fiore, Bonaventure sees the spiritual church as the culmination of a continual progression into contemplative life. However, he is even more reluctant than Joachim to offer any constructive, detailed vision of the spiritual church. We have already noted Bonaventure's notion of Francis as the proleptic presence of the Seraphic Order that will flourish in the final age of the Church. McGinn and Ratzinger both understand this ecstatic contemplation, the culmination of the hierarchy of practice, to be the most essential component of Bonaventure's vision of the coming age.⁸² I agree; for the great Franciscan, the mystical union of the Seraph is the true *telos* of both the Church and the individual soul. However, for our purpose, we must contextualize this particular aspect of the seventh age within the institutional developments Bonaventure discusses.

Along with the ascent of the Church into the life of the Seraph, Bonaventure states that the

81. *Ench.* f. 70^r

82. Ratzinger, 92-3; McGinn 1985, 218.

Church will be fulfilled institutionally in the "consummating orders" of prelates, masters, and monks. "And so the consummation of the Church consists in this, that it be governed according to prelacy, according to demonstration, and according to abstention from the flesh."⁸³ This text seems to indicate that the institutional Church has **already come** to its measure of perfection in its form; these institutions were already well established in the thirteenth century. Bonaventure's Church in the seventh age seems to undergo no institutional transformation. The spiritual perfection of the Seraph is a perfection of **practice**, and it will occur within the structures of the Church as they are.

It seems proper, then, that Bonaventure speaks of the "seventh age of the Church" as a time of renewal, rather than transformation. "In the seventh time to come, there will be a *rebuilding* of divine worship and a *restoration* of the city." The "descent of the heavenly Jerusalem" of the Apocalypse refers, not to the coming of a new city from heaven, but to the Church Militant's conformity to the hierarchical heavenly City "... as much as it is possible on the pilgrim way." This conformity consists of a return to the Church "as it was in the beginning," or the *vita apostolica*. The perfection of the Church in the seventh age is the evangelical perfection, the life of the Gospel preached by Francis and fulfilled in Francis's Seraphic vision.

Note too that Bonaventure's Church militant must conform to the "*hierarchical* heavenly city." As a student of Dionysius, Bonaventure perceived perfection in terms of hierarchy. Hierarchy is the form of the divine ordering of existence. The preeminent hierarchy is of the divine persons, Father, Son, and Spirit; every other hierarchy, be it angelic, ecclesiastical, or individual, is modeled upon this divine exemplar. To the degree that each hierarchy is conformed to the Exemplar, it reaches perfection. For example, the contemplative soul is for Bonaventure the "hierarchized soul,"⁸⁴ which has "some measure of perfection through which to see the visions of God."⁸⁵ The same is true of the Church, for "the contemplative Church and the contemplative soul do not differ, but that what the soul has entirely within itself, the Church has in many."⁸⁶ The centrality of "hierarchy" in this text underscores the point made above: The Church is fulfilled in proper hierarchy, and this is already fulfilled in the institutions of the Roman Church. Bonaventure, always the good churchman, sees no necessary discontinuity between the hierarchy of his time and the Church of the seventh age; in fact, there is no discontinuity at all. The Church will become spiritual and contemplative in its practice (*exercitia*) within its current institutions. When the entire Church practices the poverty of Francis and is united to God in the Seraphic Order, then all shall share in the contemplative knowledge of God.

83. "Consistit ergo in hoc consummatio Ecclesiae, ut regatur secundum rationem praelationis, secundum rationem illustrationis, secundum rationem a carne abstractionis." *Collatio* XXII.9.

84. "*anima hierarchizata*." *Collatio* XXIII.2.

85. "*Quaelibet enim anima contemplativa habet quandam perfectionem ut videat visiones Dei*." *Collatio* XXIII.4.

86. "*Ecclesia enim contemplativa et anima non differunt, nisi quod anima totum habet in se, quod Ecclesia in multis*." *Collatio* XXIII.4.

"And then there shall be peace."⁸⁷

Peter Olivi could not share this optimistic vision of the institutional Church in the seventh age. We have already seen that Olivi believed that the Church of the fifth age was a Church in decline. The things of this world had led the carnal nature of the Church astray. With Francis, at the dawn of the sixth age, parts of the Church experienced a radical transformation and rebirth. Olivi's own time was a unique locus of conflict at the cusp-point between the declining carnal Church of the fifth and sixth ages and the spiritual Church of the sixth and seventh. So great is the depravity of the carnal Church that it cannot be saved by reform; rather, it will be destroyed by outside armies. The spiritual Church then will emerge triumphant and perhaps relocate the seat of the Church from Rome to Jerusalem or some other site, symbolically rejecting everything Roman:

In the year after the antichrist, this city [Rome] will once again be renewed, that the principal throne of Christ will remain there unto the end of the age, as it was earlier from the time of Christ. Or after the Antichrist, Christ will return his seat to the place from whence it flowed to Rome, Jerusalem, or to another place (to be left to his arrangement)⁸⁸

While he does not assert with confidence that Rome's pre-eminence will be stripped, the very suggestion that the seat will return to Jerusalem points to a renovation of the evangelical, apostolic life and the passing of the Roman Church as an institution. Whether this will happen or not, Olivi clearly emphasizes one fact: Between the institutional Church of the first five ages and the spiritual Church, which is born and grows in the sixth age, there is a clear and radical discontinuity.

The Church that will be destroyed in the sixth age will no longer be in God's favor. Using the Biblical image of the kingship of Israel, Olivi describes the transfer of blessing and authority from the carnal to the spiritual Church:

For just as, when David had been anointed and the spirit of the Lord was upon him, the Spirit of the Lord drew back from Saul more than before and a vile spirit tormented him, so, too, from the time when the Spirit of the Lord manifestly was sent upon the poor men of the evangelical life, choosing them and anointing them for the office of preaching with apostolic authority, many began to be stirred against the poor ones by a diabolic spirit, and they began to be pressed into simony and luxury, avarice, festivals, and enormous pomposity. Then it was that the Sun of faith and of the guidance of the Church became black, like a sack woven from the hair of swine and beasts.⁸⁹

87. "... et tunc pax erit." *Collatio* XVI.30.

88. "... anno autem post antichristum hec urbs iterum reparetur ut ibi usque ad finem seculi stet principalis sedes christi sicut fuit a tempore christi, aut christus post antichristum reducat suam sedem ad locum unde manavit ad urbem romam puta in ierusalem vel alibi sue dispositioni [sic] est relinquendum: neutrum enim horum potest certificari ex sacro textu nec aliquo certo et catholico dogmate fidei christiane." Excerpt from *Apoc.*'s commentary on Apocalypse 17. Tocco, 53.

89. "Sicut enim Davide inuncto et spiritu Domini in eum directo spiritus Domini recessit a Saul plus quam ante et exagitabat eum spiritus nequam, sic ex quo in pauperes evangelicos fuit manifeste spiritus Domini directus, eos ad officium praedicationis auctoritate apostolica

As Saul had lost favor with God, so, too, had the Church of the first five ages. The mantle of leadership had passed to the "poor men of the evangelical life," the Franciscans. As Saul had made war upon David, so, too, the carnal Church attacks the new Church. The old Church authority, the Roman hierarchy, has become black with sin, and it can no longer lead the Church. The Franciscans, possessed of apostolic authority, will be the leaders of the spiritual Church in the seventh age.

We have seen above that Olivi considered Francis's resurrection as a possible event of the sixth and seventh ages. With Francis's return, he will lead his followers into the seventh age as he led them into the sixth.⁹⁰ But their rule will not simply be a new hierarchy. In the spiritual Church, internal and external authority will be joined, so that the Franciscans will (literally) rule by their Rule. "...[T]he evangelical order of holy men who resemble Christ and his way of life ... are to possess the crown or authority of the emperor or pope at the end of the world, along with the power and the office to gather in the final harvest."⁹¹ The life of evangelical poverty will allow them to rule more by example than by coercion. Olivi hereby condemns the hierarchical structure of the Roman Church as it has developed in the first five ages of the Church.⁹² The *ecclesia spiritualis* of the seventh age is entirely new in structure, authority, and way of life.

Peter Olivi offers a spiritual Church that is more egalitarian in its structure, more spontaneous in its authority, and more Franciscan in its way of life than that of either Joachim or Bonaventure. Whereas Joachim and Bonaventure had emphasized the centrality of a "spiritualized" hierarchy, more or less continuous with the Roman Church, Olivi envisions a Church of spontaneous authority shaped by the example of the evangelical life and de-emphasizes the role of any particular office. Olivi's *ecclesia*

destinans et inungens, coeperunt multi contra eos diabolico spiritu agitari et in simonias et Luxurias et avaritas et festus et pompas enormiter praecipitari; unde sol fidei et ecclesiastici regiminis factus est niger et quasi saccus de pilis porcorum et ferarum contextus." excerpt from *Apoc.* in Döllinger, 542.

90. *Apoc.* 55^{rb}. cf. Note 48 above.

91. " *principaliter designat hic evangelicum ordinem sanctorum Christo et eius vite similitum et regiam seu pontificalem coronam seu auctoritatem circa finem seculi habiturorum cum potestate et officio collegendi finalem messem electorum.*" *Apoc.* 96^{vb}.

92. Scholars have tried to puzzle out exactly how Olivi felt about the Pontifical office and the rest of the Roman hierarchy. In defense of poverty, Olivi never hesitated to invoke the papal decree *Exiit qui seminat*, so some have wondered whether Olivi's rhetoric carried him further than he really would have liked to go. As I have said, Olivi believed the mark of the carnal Church he condemned was to be found solely in its opposition to the evangelical life of poverty. Any part of the hierarchy which supported Francis's life was therefore not part of the carnal Church.

Olivi's radical condemnation of the hierarchy here results from two factors in Olivi's thought. First, he was convinced thoroughly that a Pope (pseudopope) would ascend to the Chair of Peter who would try to stamp out the evangelical life. At that point, in Olivi's near future, the entire Church of Rome would be lost to Babylon. This was the Church Olivi prophetically condemns outright. Secondly, Olivi's belief in Christ's direct teaching lurks behind his belief in the authority of the coming Church. While his particular doctrine of direct revelation espouses nothing particularly different from what Joachim or Bonaventure say, Olivi seems to connect this doctrine to a notion of authority. If we view Olivi as a prophetic figure, this is not uncommon. (cf. Hildegard of Bingen, etc.)

of the seventh age suggests itself as an example of what Norman Cohn has called the "millennium": a collective, terrestrial, imminent, sudden, total, and miraculous replacement of the existing Church by a new reign of peace and blessedness.⁹³ As such, it is quite different from the progressive apocalyptic spiritual Church espoused by Bonaventure and Joachim. It is a Church in which Christ truly "makes all things new." (Rev. 21:5)

Perhaps this difference between Olivi and his intellectual predecessors is to be attributed to his particular historical context and social location. As a member of the more radical "spiritual" wing of his order, in the midst of the continuing controversy over poverty, Olivi adopted a more critical stance toward the Roman See and the Church it led. But this critical, prophetic voice in no way diminishes his debt to the Abbot and the Doctor before him. The doctrine of a contemplative age within history, in which *intellectus spiritualis* would flourish and the Church would be renewed, is common to all three.

And for all three, this contemplative age is the culmination of an apocalyptic journey through the course of history. The Church (or, for Olivi, the spiritual "elect" within the Church) has moved into a deeper knowledge of God through a spiritual understanding tied to the Scriptures. Christ will now teach the entire Church directly, without mediation and without mystery. All will enjoy this direct revelation with sweetness, unction, and clarity. The very structures of the Church will reflect this mystical knowledge of God, whether by the perfection of the sevenfold *novus ordo* of Joachim, the fully hierarchized Church of Bonaventure, or the spontaneous, blessed communion of Olivi. In sum, the contemplative age represents the fulfillment and destination of the pilgrim Church on earth, where she will enjoy the mystical fullness of the presence of God in history.

CONCLUSION: The Mystical Dimension of Joachimist Theology

For Joachim of Fiore, St. Bonaventure, and Peter Olivi, history is the stage of an apocalyptic drama that leads the Church as a social body "farther up and farther in," and culminates in the mystical knowledge of God. Each man construed the particular details of this historical journey in a unique and coherent theological vision. For Joachim, this history is above all the history of exegesis. Since Christ's resurrection, the Church has progressively moved from the 'skin' of the letter to the 'heart' of spiritual understanding. This spiritual understanding will flourish in the third *status*, the age of the Holy Spirit, when the very life and structure of the Church will reflect this deeper knowledge in a diverse, hierarchical life of monastic perfection.

Bonaventure's history is the mystical ascent of the Church through the dionysian hierarchies. Primarily, it is the history of *exercitia*, of practice, developing from the active life, through the mixed life, and into the contemplation of God. The twin foci of this contemplative practice are spiritual

93. Cf., Norman Cohn, *The Pursuit of the Millennium*, 2nd. ed. (New York, 1970), 15. Cohn's notion of the "millennium" seems fundamentally sound, but he applies it too broadly to apocalypticism in general. Olivi's Church seems to be the sort he had in mind, but, as others have argued and as this paper hopefully has shown, Olivi's is not the only apocalyptic option.

understanding and the evangelical life of poverty. Naturally, then, St. Francis stands in history as the exemplar and lure, drawing the Church behind him into the proper hierarchy of practice. Then the hierarchies of the Church and the soul will both be conformed more perfectly to the divine hierarchy, and the Church will enjoy peace and blessedness.

Peter Olivi's history, like Bonaventure's, is a history of practice. More specifically, it is a history focused upon the evangelical life of poverty. Through four ages, the Church progressed toward this goal with zeal. But the Church abandoned its zealous pursuit in the fifth age and turned to the world's luxury and power for solace. But, with Christ's spiritual advent in Francis of Assisi, the evangelical life was reborn. The followers of Francis usher in a new age, and, with it, a new Church of spiritual understanding, charismatic authority and apostolic poverty.

Each thinker presents a distinct vision of the journey of the Church toward God in history, and the details of each itinerary have been well discussed by McGinn, Ratzinger, and Burr, among others. What I hope to have contributed by bringing the three together in this essay is the way in which the commonalities among the three share an insight into history as mystagogy, as God's luring of the Church into contemplative union. Even more, all three express the ways in which this eschatological union is a social phenomenon, in which the entire Church is drawn into the knowledge of God. The institutional structures of the Church will themselves reflect this mystical elevation and perfection. In the future contemplative age, the Church is transformed into a community of mystical fellowship governed by charismatic authority. In the fusion of mystical and apocalyptic Christian traditions, Joachim of Fiore, Bonaventure, and Peter Olivi present an apocalyptic theology of history in a mystical key.

However, this does not constitute Buonaiuti's 'second type' of mysticism in the *vita associata*. If Joachim, Bonaventure, and Olivi arrive at their particular teachings through their discernment of a mystical dimension in the theology of history, this represents in fact a *recovery* of elements essential but often forgotten in the tradition.⁹⁴ Eastern Christian scholars are quick to point out that the mystical theology of Pseudo-Dionysius is centered upon the liturgy, literally the 'work of the people,' the social work of communion between God and the Church gathered in worship.⁹⁵ As such, mystical theology is both the summit and the subtext to all theological work. It encompasses the life of the Church.

M.-D. Chenu was correct: "la vie mystique c'est n'autre, en son fond, que la vie chrétienne." The mystical life is the Christian life lived in its deepest intensity. As such, all the dimensions of the

94. See Bernard McGinn's recent work on the common roots and various Christian recombinations of apocalypticism and mysticism in his essay, "Apocalypticism and Mysticism: Aspects of the History of Their Interaction." [as yet unpublished.] N.B., I am not arguing that there are historically identifiable documentary connections between Joachim and, say, Maximus the Confessor. However, as McGinn points out, Joachim does seem to favor (and to historicize) Paul's discussion of the ascent to the 'third heaven' in 2 Cor. 12.

95. See Andrew Louth, *Wisdom of the Byzantine Church: Evagrius of Pontos and Maximus the Confessor*. 1997 Paine Lectures in Religion, ed. Jill Raitt. (Columbia, MO: University of Missouri, 1998), and Dom Julian Stead, OSB's Commentary on Maximus's Mystagogy, *The Church, the Liturgy, and the Soul of Man* (Still River, MA: St. Bede's Publications, 1982).

Christian life – personal, social, historical – and theological reflection upon these dimensions, may be taken in a mystical key, or at least be illuminated by the insights of mystical theology. What is offered here is but one instance in which such theological illumination has taken place. Joachim, Bonaventure, and Olivi argue in their theologies of history for the ways in which history itself may be seen as a ‘song of ascents’ sung by the Church together in anticipation of the time “when God will be all in all.” (1 Cor. 15.28)⁹⁶

96. What begs for further exploration here is whether these insights, so wed to a progressive vision of history, might be applied analogically to a non-progressive construal of history. Denys Turner’s recent work has pointed to the ways in which the medieval scalar or itinerary-model of mystical thought is misleadingly linear, such that one might conclude that the apophatic mode picks up where the cataphatic left off. (Turner, “The Darkness of God and the Light of Christ: Negative Theology and Eucharistic Presence” *Modern Theology* 15:2 (April 1999), 143-158) This less linear reading of mystical theology might dovetail well with what Miroslav Volf has called a ‘kaleidoscopic’ vision of history, in which “social arrangements [and I would add ‘individuals, cultures, and institutions’] shift in various ways under various influences ... without necessarily following an evolutionist or involutionist pattern.” (Volf, *Work in the Spirit: Toward a Theology of Work* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1991), 84) In a ‘kaleidoscopic’ view of history, such shifting arrangements will sometimes reflect the light of Christ and illumine other elements, and at other times they may obscure it. Might we think of the ‘mystical path of the Church’ in a similar vein – as sometimes reflecting Christ beautifully, and sometimes not, without any clearly identifiable overarching marks of overall decline or progress?